CHAPTER 1 | SEGREGATED SECTORS

Leonard Freed, the Berlin Crisis, and the Color Line

> If the American found in Europe only confusion, it would obviously be infinitely wiser for him to remain at home. Hidden, however, in the heart of confusion he encounters here is that which he came so blindly seeking: the terms on which he is related to his country, and to the world.
> —JAMES BALDWIN

On August 13, 1961, East German forces closed the borders of East Berlin and, in turn, encircled the allied sectors of the city's western half. Two weeks later, American photographer Leonard Freed wandered along the internal edges of the divided city. In those uncertain days of the Berlin Crisis, each side was on high alert, as the potential for conflict in Berlin between the superpowers seemed imminent, leading to a standoff and the eventual sealing of the city's western sectors. It would take the East German Democratic Republic months to fully enclose West Berlin, but within a matter of hours and days, the newly fortified boundary was beginning to take shape: barbed wire, wooden barricades, torn-up pavement, bricks, and the rudimentary beginnings of a concrete wall. In the weeks that followed, soldiers from each side drew near to protect and inspect the implementation of the closed border.[1]

Freed was fascinated by the implications of this Cold War front line. Berlin was again the epicenter of global conflict, in what he conceived as "a war of nerves" between the Soviet-led East and American-allied West.[2] By August 1961 Freed had been living outside America for more than five years. During his August travels, he spent his time close to the center of the partitioned city. With the world on the brink of war, he pointed his camera toward one of the West's last lines of defense: American GIs in the American sector of West Berlin. These new images summoned an impulse to seek out American subjects, a focus that had been only latent in his European work up to this point.

From his earliest travels to Germany in the early 1950s, Freed pondered the ways in which history and memory influenced the nation's postwar condition and, in turn, his own relationship to its people and landscapes. He